voters. The BJP started winning because it was acting differently from the other parties. Its policy actions contributed to more women voting for the BJP than men did in 2019. They did so partly because the Modi government fulfilled many of its promises in terms of governmental benefits, especially for rural women. If it had only been about creating women-focused schemes, then all governments in the past have done so. What then differentiated the BJP politically on the women question? In mid-2018, Modi provided some clarity on this issue. His strategy had two pillars: one, collating diverse women-focused schemes in a single basket so there was one direction and it became possible to have cohesive political communications around it, and, two, pushing gender-focused welfare measures for women at every stage in their lifecycle, from the cradle to the grave. Addressing a group of BJP workers, Modi acknowledged that 'for women's empowerment, earlier too many schemes were made', but 'there was no one direction' and they were 'not connected to the small-small needs of women'. Stressing on the point that 'collecting all schemes in one direction' creates 'a new kind of power', the prime minister pushed a narrative of gender-based welfare interventions. 'This is why Bharatiya Janata Party started working with one approach,' he said. 'From the time a woman gets pregnant, gives birth to children, education of children, career of the children—in one way, from the time of a woman's birth to death, at every milestone, our approach has been, how can government be helpful and provide governmental support. How can we increase the speed of this work and we have focused all our schemes in this manner.'[98]

The biggest marker of Modi's approach was the large share of women beneficiaries in general government schemes that were not women-specific (see Figure 17.11). Women accounted for 68 per cent of loans under the PMMY, which provides credit to micro enterprises to bring them into the formal economy. Loans were given to 16.64 crore women from a cumulative credit of ₹5,43,943 crore over a five-year period (2016–2020).[99] One of the three categories of loans given under the Mudra scheme was, of course, targeted at women's groups alone. However, women also accounted for a significant percentage of the overall scheme benefits. Each of these 16.64 crore women who got Mudra loans represented a family or a